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Grant Writing Masterclass

Module 4 — The Cover Letter

Student Course Companion

Name: _____ Organization: _____

Team / Cohort (if applicable): _____

This workbook is your hands-on companion to Module 4. Each section is designed to help you understand the cover letter formula, see it in action, and draft your own. If you are working as a team, look for the green team discussion boxes throughout.

Section 1 — Key Terms & Concepts

These are the core concepts behind every element of a strong cover letter. Review them before moving into the exercises.

Cover Letter	The first page of your grant proposal. Introduces your organization, states the ask, and makes a compelling case for why the funder should keep reading. Often the only page a program officer reads before deciding whether to give your proposal serious consideration.
Specific Ask	A precise dollar amount requested — never a range or an approximation. Always accompanied by a clear explanation of how the funds will be used and how that use aligns with the funder's priorities.
Opening Hook	The first element of your cover letter after the salutation. Must immediately pull the reader in using one of three approaches: a compelling participant story, a powerful statistic, or a sincere and specific thank-you to a returning funder.
Track Record	A concise summary of your organization's history, reach, and accomplishments. Positioned in the cover letter to demonstrate that funding your organization is a low-risk, high-impact

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	investment.
Mission Alignment	The explicit connection between your funding request and the funder's stated priorities. Must be named directly — not implied. The cover letter is where you make this connection before the funder ever opens the narrative.
Site Visit Invitation	A brief, confident invitation for the funder to visit your program in action. Opens the door to a deeper relationship and positions your organization as confident in its work.
Dual Signature	Both the Board Chair and the Chief Executive Officer must sign the cover letter. Signals organizational unity, board engagement, and leadership commitment. A letter signed only by a staff member sends a weaker message.
Contact Information	Your direct phone number, email address, and organization website — included in the cover letter so a program officer can reach you without searching. Never make a funder hunt for this.
Credibility Statement	A sentence or two in the cover letter that establishes how long you have operated, who you serve, how many people you have impacted, and what you have achieved. Not a brochure — a confidence-building summary.
One-Page Rule	A cover letter must fit on a single page. Every sentence must earn its place. Brevity signals respect for the funder's time and confidence in your case.

Section 2 — Annotated Example

Read the sample cover letter below. The right column explains what each paragraph is doing and why it works. As you read, note the techniques you want to use in your own letter.

Sample Cover Letter — Full Annotated Draft

COVER LETTER TEXT	WHY IT WORKS
<i>Ms. Patricia Okonkwo</i> <i>Director of Community Grants</i> <i>The Hartwell Family Foundation</i>	→ Addressed to a specific, named individual → Name + title + foundation = proof you did your homework. Never use

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Dear Ms. Okonkwo, <i>In 2022, Daria was 16 years old, reading at a fifth-grade level, and on the verge of dropping out. Today she is a high school graduate enrolled in a community college nursing program. Workforce Pathways made that possible — and your investment will make it possible for 90 more young people just like her this year.</i>	“Dear Sir or Madam.” → Opens with a real participant story → Specific details (age, grade level, outcome) make it vivid and credible → Connects the funder’s future investment to a human outcome before the ask
<i>Founded in 2007, Workforce Pathways has served 6,400 adults across 14 program sites. In our most recent year, 83% of completers secured employment within 90 days. We have administered \$4.1M in grants with no audit exceptions and a 100% on-time reporting record.</i> <i>We respectfully request \$65,000 to fund our 16-week career readiness cohort serving 90 adults in the metro area. This request directly supports the Hartwell Foundation’s 2025 priority to expand economic mobility for workforce-disconnected adults.</i>	→ Years of operation + reach + outcome % = credibility in three sentences → Specific dollar ask — not a range → Alignment is explicit: echoes the funder’s own priority language
<i>I welcome any questions and can be reached directly at (555) 214-8800 or director@workforcepathways.org. Our website at www.workforcepathways.org includes recent program data and participant testimonials. We would be honored to welcome you to our next cohort graduation — it is a powerful reminder of what this work makes possible.</i>	→ Direct phone + email + website — all three included → Site visit invitation is specific and confident — not a vague “feel free to contact us”
Respectfully submitted, _____ _____ Maria Delgado James Osei Executive Director Board Chair	→ Both signatures present — Executive Director and Board Chair → Signals organizational unity and board engagement. A letter signed only by a grant writer sends a weaker message.

□ **Team:** As a group, read through the annotated example. Which of the seven elements does your organization do consistently well? Which one needs the most attention before your next submission?

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Section 3 — Before & After Comparisons

Each pair shows a weak and strong version of a cover letter element. Study the difference, then answer the reflection question below each pair.

Comparison 1 — The Opening Hook

☐ Weak

My name is Sandra Torres and I am the Executive Director of Community First Services. Our organization would like to apply for a grant from your foundation to support our youth mentorship program.

☐ Strong

Last spring, Jaylen was failing three classes and had stopped attending school altogether. Six months into our mentorship program, he had a 3.1 GPA and was accepted into his first-choice high school. That is what this funding makes possible — and we are asking for the opportunity to do it for 80 more young people.

☐ What did the strong version do in the first two sentences that the weak version failed to do in the entire paragraph?

☐ **Team discussion:** Share two or three real participant stories from your organization's work. As a group, choose the one that most vividly shows impact in human terms.

Comparison 2 — The Credibility Statement

☐ Weak

We are a well-established organization that has been helping people in our community for many years. Our dedicated staff works hard every day to make a difference.

☐ Strong

Founded in 2011, Bright Futures has served 5,200 youth across nine program sites. In our most recent year, 88% of participants improved their academic standing, and we managed \$2.8M in grant funds with no audit findings.

☐ Write a three-sentence credibility statement for your own organization: years in operation, number served, and your strongest outcome statistic.

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☐ **Team discussion:** *Does everyone on your team know your organization's key data points? Assign someone to compile: years operating, total people served, top outcome statistic, and grant history.*

Comparison 3 — The Specific Ask

☐ **Weak**

We are requesting somewhere between \$40,000 and \$60,000 to help fund our programs. The exact amount will depend on what is available. We are flexible and will use whatever you are able to provide.

☐ **Strong**

We respectfully request \$48,000 to fund staff salaries, curriculum materials, and participant transportation for our 10-month after-school literacy program serving 65 students at Roosevelt Elementary. This request directly supports your foundation's commitment to closing the literacy gap in underserved urban communities.

☐ **Write your own specific ask statement: dollar amount, program name, what it funds, number served, and alignment with the funder's priorities.**

☐ **Team discussion:** *As a team, confirm your program budget before writing the ask. What is the total cost? What percentage are you requesting from this funder? Does that percentage follow the 10% guideline from Module 3?*

Comparison 4 — The Site Visit Invitation

☐ **Weak**

Please feel free to contact us if you have any questions. We are happy to provide more information if needed.

☐ **Strong**

We would welcome the opportunity to introduce you to the families we serve and show you our program in action. Our next community showcase is scheduled for March 14th — we would be honored to reserve a place for you.

☐ **Write a site visit invitation for your own organization. Be specific about what the funder would see and why it would be meaningful.**

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☐ **Team discussion:** Does your organization have a scheduled event, graduation, demonstration, or site tour you could invite funders to? Add one to the calendar if not.

Section 4 — Your Cover Letter Builder

Complete each prompt in order. When you are done, you will have a first draft of every element your cover letter needs. Follow the seven-step formula from the module.

Step 1 — Address It to a Specific Person

☐ **Funder name and program:**

☐ **Name and title of the program officer or executive director you will address:**

☐ **Tip:** If you cannot find the name on the foundation's website, call their main number and ask. One phone call separates your proposal from dozens that say "Dear Sir or Madam."

Step 2 — Your Opening Hook

Choose one approach and draft it in the space below.

☐ Participant story ☐ Compelling statistic ☐ Sincere thank-you to a returning funder

☐ **Write your opening hook (2–3 sentences maximum):**

☐ **Team discussion:** Share your draft hooks as a group. Does it make you lean in? Is it specific enough to be credible? Could it apply to any organization, or does it feel uniquely yours?

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★Example — Participant story hook:

In 2023, Rosa was 17, three credits behind, and working two jobs to help her family pay rent. Today she has her diploma and starts a medical assistant certification program in January. That is what this funding makes possible.

★Example — Statistic hook:

One in four adults in our region lacks the foundational literacy skills needed for stable employment. Our program has been closing that gap since 2009 — and this grant will allow us to reach 120 more people next year.

Step 3 — Your Credibility Statement

☐ Year founded:

☐ Total number of people served (most recent program year):

☐ Your strongest outcome statistic (with a percentage or measurable result):

☐ Grant history: total amount managed and any compliance highlights (e.g., no audit findings, 100% on-time reporting):

☐ **Tip:** Three sentences is enough. Year founded. Who you serve and how many. Your strongest result. Then stop.

Step 4 — Your Specific Ask

☐ Dollar amount requested: \$ _____

☐ What will the funds pay for? (Be specific: staff, materials, services, number of people served)

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- ☐ How does this request align with the funder's stated priorities? (Quote or paraphrase their language.)
-

☐ **Team discussion:** *Confirm as a team that your ask amount is specific, justified by your budget, and represents no more than 10% of your total program budget for a new funder relationship.*

Step 5 — Contact Information

- ☐ Executive Director name and direct phone:
-

- ☐ Direct email address:
-

- ☐ Organization website:
-

Step 6 — Site Visit Invitation

- ☐ Write your site visit invitation. Name a specific event, graduation, or program activity if possible.
-

Step 7 — Signatures

- ☐ Executive Director name (for signature line):
-

- ☐ Board Chair name (for signature line):
-

☐ **Tip:** *Confirm who will physically sign the letter and when. Build signature logistics into your submission timeline — never leave it for the last day.*

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Section 5 — Cover Letter Self-Audit Checklist

Use this checklist to review your cover letter draft before submission. Every box should be checked. Unchecked boxes are revisions, not options.

Addressing & Salutation

- ☐ The letter is addressed to a specific, named individual — not “Dear Sir or Madam” or “To Whom It May Concern.”
- ☐ I have confirmed the correct spelling of the recipient’s name and their current title.

The Opening Hook

- ☐ My cover letter opens with a compelling story, a powerful statistic, or a sincere and specific thank-you — not with my organization’s name or a statement about applying.
- ☐ The opening is two to three sentences maximum and immediately draws the reader in.
- ☐ If I used a participant story, it includes specific details (age, outcome, timeframe) that make it vivid and credible.
- ☐ If I used a statistic, it is current, sourced, and directly relevant to the problem my program addresses.
- ☐ If I used a thank-you, it references a specific prior grant and a specific outcome it produced.

Credibility & Track Record

- ☐ I have included the year my organization was founded.
- ☐ I have stated how many people we served in the most recently completed program year.
- ☐ I have included at least one specific outcome statistic — not a vague statement about impact.
- ☐ I have referenced my organization’s grant management history (total managed, audit record, or reporting record).

The Ask

- ☐ I have requested a specific dollar amount — not a range.
- ☐ I have explained exactly what the funds will pay for (program components, number of people served).

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- ☐ I have explicitly connected my request to the funder's stated priorities using their language.

Contact & Invitation

- ☐ I have included my direct phone number, email address, and organization website.
- ☐ I have included a site visit invitation that is specific and confident.

Signatures & Format

- ☐ The letter is signed by both the Executive Director and the Board Chair.
- ☐ I have confirmed who will sign and have built signature time into my submission schedule.
- ☐ The letter is one page. Every sentence earns its place.

Revisions I need to make before submission:

☐ **Team:** Assign each revision a team member and a deadline. Write names next to each item above before leaving this session.

*"Your cover letter is your first impression,
your handshake, and your elevator pitch
all rolled into one page.
One page. Done right.
It can open doors that a hundred-page proposal alone never could."*
— Grant Writing Masterclass, Module 4